



Specifying and Analyzing Transactional Consistency Models with Predicates

Hengfeng Wei Si Liu Yuxing Chen
Hunan University

The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shenzhen

Renmin University of China

September 4, 2026

A semantic and graph-theoretic foundation for transactional consistency with predicates

Item Operations vs. Predicate Operations

Read(x, v)

Write(x, v)

names a key

returns a value

Employee

EID	Salary
X	8
Y	10
Z	6

PredRead(P, M)

$P : \text{Salary} < 9$

$M : \{X \mapsto 8, Z \mapsto 6\}$

names a condition

returns a set M of **matched** values

What we know about transactional consistency
without predicates

Review: Specs

Cerone, Bernardi, and Gotsman, 2015

A Framework for Transactional Consistency Models with Atomic Visibility

Andrea Cerone, Giovanni Bernardi, and Alexey Gotsman

IMDEA Software Institute, Madrid, Spain

(VIS, AR)

Crooks et al., 2017

Seeing is Believing: A Client-Centric Specification of Database Isolation

Natacha Crooks

The University of Texas at Austin and Cornell University

Lorenzo Alvisi

The University of Texas at Austin and Cornell University

Yuer Pu

Cornell University

Allen Clement

Google, Inc.

Client-Centric Views

Biswas and Enea, 2019

On the Complexity of Checking Transactional Consistency

RANADEEP BISWAS, Université de Paris, IRIF, CNRS, France

CONSTANTIN ENEA, Université de Paris, IRIF, CNRS, France

Checking Complexity

Review: Dependency Graphs

Adya, 1999

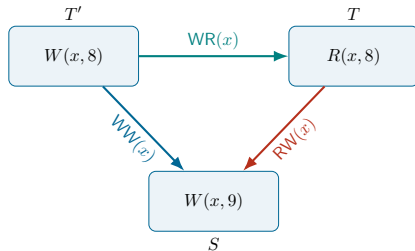
Weak Consistency: A Generalized Theory and Optimistic Implementations for Distributed Transactions

by

Atul Adya

Submitted to the Department of Electrical Engineering and Computer Science
in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of

Doctor of Philosophy



WR write-read dependency

WW write-write dependency

RW read-write anti-dependency

Review: SER Characterization

Adya, 1999

**Weak Consistency: A Generalized Theory and Optimistic
Implementations for Distributed Transactions**

by

Atul Adya

Submitted to the Department of Electrical Engineering and Computer Science
in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of

Doctor of Philosophy

Bernstein, Hadzilacos, and Goodman, 1987

**Concurrency Control
and Recovery
in Database Systems**

P.A. BERNSTEIN • V. HADZILACOS • N. GOODMAN

Theorem (roughly stated)

*An item-operation history is serializable iff
its dependency graph is acyclic.*

Review: SI Characterization

Cerone and Gotsman, 2018

Analysing Snapshot Isolation

ANDREA CERONE, Imperial College London, UK
ALEXEY GOTSMAN, IMDEA Software Institute, Spain

Theorem (roughly stated)

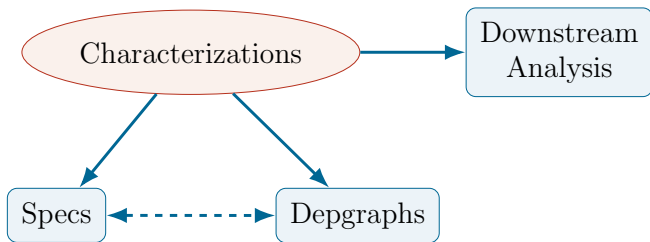
An item-operation history satisfies SI iff every cycle of its dependency graph has at least two adjacent anti-dependency (RW) edges.

Review: Downstream Analysis

Task	Representative work
History checking	Kingsbury and Alvaro, 2020; Tan et al., 2020; Huang et al., 2023; Cai et al., 2025
Protocol verification	Xiong, 2020
Program robustness	Bernardi and Gotsman, 2016

Review (Summary)

What we know about transactional consistency
without predicates



What we know about transactional consistency
with predicates

Review: Predicate-Aware Specs

Bouajjani, Enea, and Román-Calvo, 2025

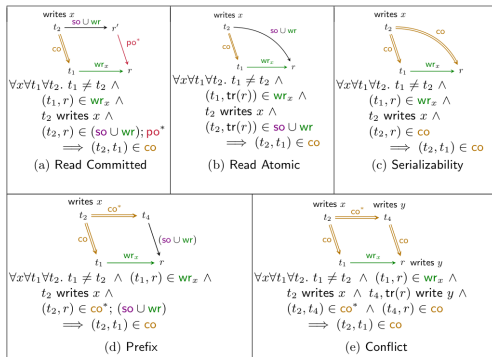
On the Complexity of Checking Mixed Isolation Levels for SQL Transactions

Ahmed Bouajjani¹, Constantin Enea², and Enrique Román-Calvo¹



¹ Université Paris Cité, CNRS, IRIF
{abou, calvo}@irif.fr

² LIX, École Polytechnique, CNRS and
Institut Polytechnique de Paris
cenea@lix.polytechnique.fr



On checking complexity and algorithms; No dependency-graph correspondence

Review: Dependency Graphs

Adya, 1999

Weak Consistency: A Generalized Theory and Optimistic Implementations for Distributed Transactions

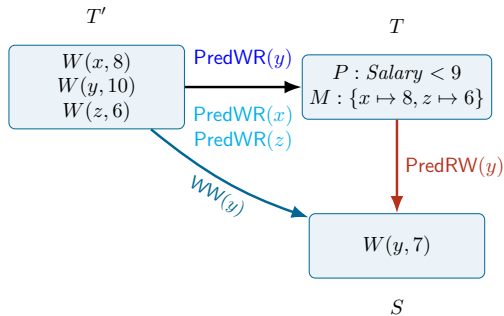
by

Atul Adya

Submitted to the Department of Electrical Engineering and Computer Science
in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of

Doctor of Philosophy

T also “observes” **unmatched** $W(y, 10)$ of T'



S later than T' **changes matches** of T on y

Review: Predicate-Aware Dependency Graphs

$$\text{PredRW}^+ \subseteq \text{PredRW} \subseteq \text{PredRW}^- \quad (T \xrightarrow{\text{PredRW}(x)} S)$$

PredRW

Adya, 1999

Weak Consistency: A Generalized Theory and Optimistic Implementations for Distributed Transactions

by

Atul Adya

Submitted to the Department of Electrical Engineering and Computer Science
in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of

Doctor of Philosophy

S changes matches

PredRW⁺

Sun and Zou, 2025

Vbox: Efficient Black-Box Serializability Verification

Anonymous Author(s)

the “earliest” S

No uniform definition of predicate-anti-dependency

(No uniform definition of predicate-read-dependency either)

PredRW⁻

Bouajjani, Enea, and Román-Calvo,
2025 (this work; CAV-inspired)

On the Complexity of Checking Mixed Isolation Levels for SQL Transactions

Ahmed Bouajjani¹, Constantin Enea², and Enrique Román-Calvo¹

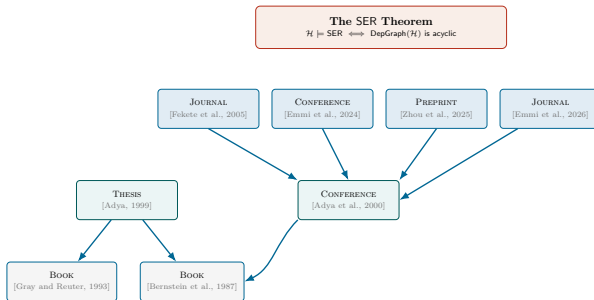


¹ Université Paris Cité, CNRS, IRIF
{abou, calvo}@irif.fr

² LIX, École Polytechnique, CNRS and
Institut Polytechnique de Paris
cenea@lix.polytechnique.fr

S overwrites x ,
drops “change matches”

Review: Predicate-Aware SER Characterization



3.4 Correctness and Flexibility of the New Specifications

Our conditions for PL-3 provide the well-known notion of conflict-serializability [BHG87, GR93]. That is, $DSG(H)$ is acyclic, and G1a, and G1b are satisfied for a history H iff H is conflict-serializable. We can prove the equivalence of our PL-3 conditions with conflict-serializability using the proof given in [GR93]; our DSGs are similar to their graphs. This equivalence can also be proved along the lines of the proof given in [BHG87] for view-serializability.

Lack a rigorous proof of the correspondence with predicate-aware semantics

Review: Predicate-Aware SI Characterization

Adya, 1999

**Weak Consistency: A Generalized Theory and Optimistic
Implementations for Distributed Transactions**

by

Atul Adya

Submitted to the Department of Electrical Engineering and Computer Science
in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of

Doctor of Philosophy

Theorem 2: A history H consisting of committed transactions executes under Snapshot Isolation iff G1 and G-SI are disallowed.

G-SIa: uses low-level timing information

Definition 17: Snapshot Read. All reads performed by a transaction T_i occur at its start point. That is, if $r_i(x_j)$ occurs in history H , then:

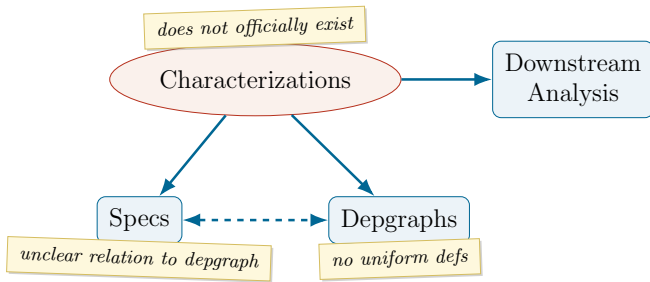
1. $c_j \prec_t s_i$, and
2. if $w_k(x_k)$ also occurs in H ($j \neq k$), then either
 - (a) $s_i \prec_t c_k$, or
 - (b) $c_k \prec_t s_i$ and $x_k \ll x_j$

Definition 18: Snapshot Write. If T_i and T_j are concurrent, they cannot both modify the same object. That is, if $w_i(x_i)$ and $w_j(x_j)$ both occur in history H , then either $c_i \prec_t s_j$ or $c_j \prec_t s_i$. This is the first-committer-wins property.

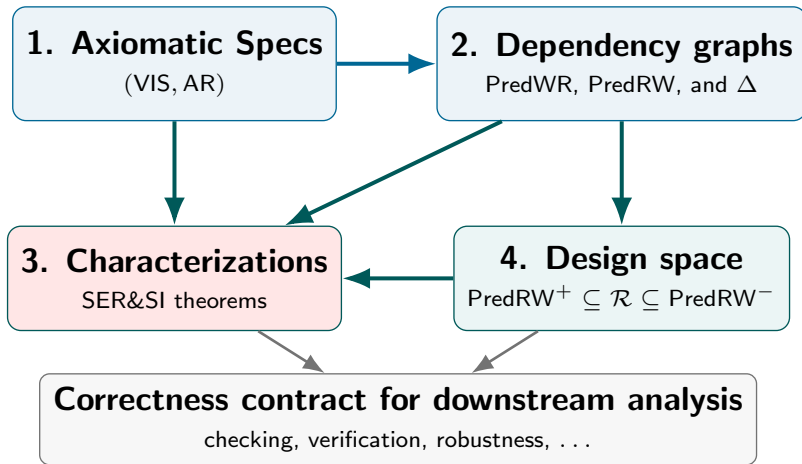
Proof relies on *item-only* properties of SI

Review (Summary)

What we know about transactional consistency
with predicates



Contributions: Fill and Exploit the Gap



1. Predicate-Aware Specs

$$\begin{aligned} & \forall T \in \mathcal{T}, P \in \mathcal{P}, M \subseteq K \times V, x \in K. T \vdash \text{PR}(P, M, x) \implies \\ & \left(\boxed{x \in \text{DOM}(M)} \implies \exists v \in V. (x, v) \in M \wedge \boxed{\max_{\text{AR}}(\text{VIS}^{-1}(T) \cap \text{WriteTx}_x)} \vdash \boxed{W(x, v)} \right) \wedge \\ & \left(\boxed{x \in K \setminus \text{DOM}(M)} \implies \forall v \in V. \left(\boxed{\max_{\text{AR}}(\text{VIS}^{-1}(T) \cap \text{WriteTx}_x)} \vdash W(x, v) \implies \boxed{\neg P(x, v)} \right) \right) \end{aligned} \quad (\text{EXT-PRED})$$

External predicate consistency (EXT-PRED axiom)

The **AR-latest visible writer** must explain either **the returned value** or **the omission**.

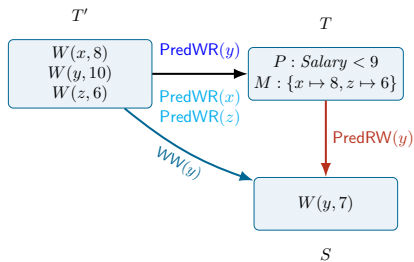
2. Predicate-Aware Dependency Graphs

Graph witness

$T' \xrightarrow{\text{PredWR}(y)} T$: record the writer explaining (the omission of) y

Observation-changing successor

$T \xrightarrow{\text{PredRW}(y)} S$: S later than T' **changes** y from non-matching to matching



3. Predicate-Aware Characterizations

Theorem (SER Characterization)

$\mathcal{H} \models \text{SER}$ iff it admits an *acyclic* predicate-aware depgraph.

Theorem (SI Characterization)

$\mathcal{H} \models \text{SI}$ iff it admits a predicate-aware depgraph where every cycle has two adjacent RW/PredRW edges.

3. Predicate-Aware Characterizations

Theorem (SER Characterization)

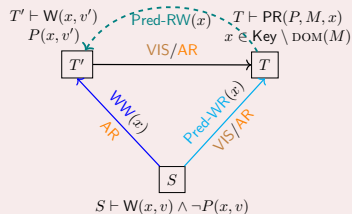
$\mathcal{H} \models \text{SER}$ iff it admits an *acyclic* predicate-aware depgraph.

Theorem (SI Characterization)

$\mathcal{H} \models \text{SI}$ iff it admits a predicate-aware depgraph where every cycle has two adjacent RW/PredRW edges.

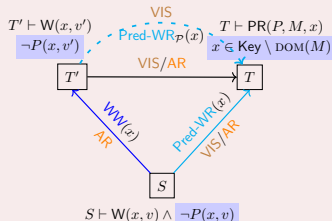
“if” direction: construct legal execution $\mathcal{A} \models \text{Ext-Pred}$ from graph

Challenge: mismatched witnesses



violation of $\text{EXT-PRED} \Rightarrow \text{PredRW} \Rightarrow$ forbidden cycle

Challenge (SI): mismatched witnesses



no need to recover the exact graph from execution $\mathcal{A}$

4. Design Space (of Predicate Anti-Dependencies)

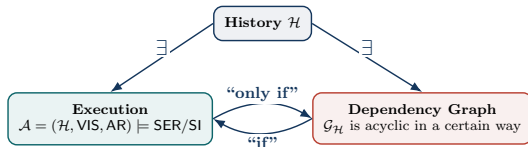
$$\text{PredRW}^+ \subseteq \mathcal{R} \subseteq \text{PredRW}^-$$

Every relation $\mathcal{R}$ preserves the same SER/SI characterization.

4. Design Space (of Predicate Anti-Dependencies)

$$\text{PredRW}^+ \subseteq \mathcal{R} \subseteq \text{PredRW}^-$$

Every relation $\mathcal{R}$ preserves the same SER/SI characterization.



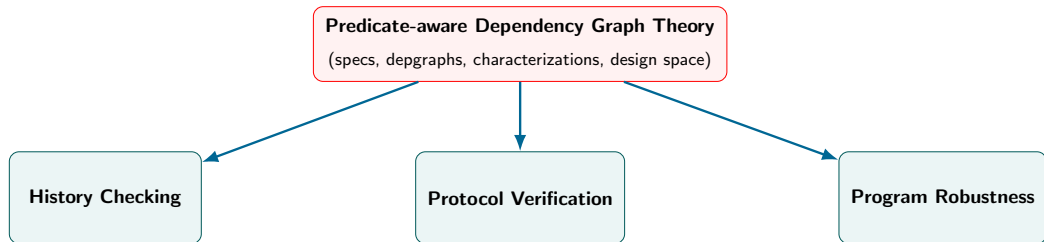
"if": $\text{PredRW}^+ \subseteq \mathcal{R}$

$\text{PredRW}^+ + \text{WW}$ recovers PredRW in reachability

"only if": $\mathcal{R} \subseteq \text{PredRW}^-$

$\text{PredWR} + \text{WW}$ suffices to derive safe AR orientation

Future Work: Downstream Analysis



[PredRW⁺, PredRW⁻]-guided history checker

- a lower persistent cycle can reject
- an upper acyclic graph can accept
- ambiguous cases are refined or solved

Takeaways: Theory Established, Downstream Analysis Enabled

1. **Predicate-aware specs.** Extend (VIS, AR) with item-wise external predicate observations.
2. **Dependency graphs.** Formally define PredRW with the “change matches” condition.
3. **SER/SI characterizations.** Prove the same execution–graph equivalence style as the item-only results, while resolving the predicate-specific SI witness ambiguity.
4. **Proof-theoretic design space.** Every relation $\text{PredRW}^+ \subseteq \mathcal{R} \subseteq \text{PredRW}^-$ preserves the same history-level characterization.

Checking, Verification, Robustness, ...